in police custody'. He even demands, but to no avail, 'will you kindly let me know by return when and where I can get the same?'.[2]

After that incident Bhagat Singh did turn to revolutionary activism but given that he was just twenty-three years old at the time of his execution, the period of his activism was just seven years, from 1924 to 1931. Clearly, a lot had to be done in these years and marriage would get in the way, so he became determined not to marry. But this was not the only reason for his not marrying. As his letters show, even as a youngster he carried the anguished memories of two forlorn aunts, Harnam Kaur and Hukam Kaur, living in the family household, but without their husbands, bereft of their love, pining for them in their abandoned state, and yet known as the wives of Ajit Singh and Sarwan Singh. Bhagat Singh decided early on that he would not cause the same despair to another young woman, who would have the poisoned chalice of marrying him. This was despite the fact that he had been betrothed from a very young age, by his grandmother, Jai Kaur, and his father, Kishan Singh, to be married to another young girl. With his older brother, Jagat Singh, having died, Bhagat Singh was now the eldest child in a family of eight children. The pressure to marry was intense. But Bhagat Singh also knew that if he married, he would not be able to participate at the highest levels of the revolutionary movement, which his involvement in the Hindustan Socialist Republican Association demanded of him, as he would have to spend long periods away from home, working secretly and remotely. He was also influenced by his mentor, Sachindra Nath Sanyal, in this decision. When the pressure came, Bhagat Singh was sixteen and studying at National College in Lahore in 1923 and had just passed his intermediate exams. That is when, to escape marriage, he fled to Kanpur in Uttar Pradesh, where he stayed with Mani Lal Avasthi.[3]

So convinced was Bhagat Singh about the incompatibility of marriage with the life of a revolutionary that he even set out to persuade his teacher, Principal Chhabil Das of National College, that Das should not do so, despite Das' protestations that eminent revolutionaries such as Sun Yat-Sen, Lenin and Karl Marx were all married.[4] However, this was not because Bhagat Singh himself frowned upon marriage as an institution. It was